

News Writing

State Meet • 2022



You are a reporter for the Leaguetown **Press**, the student newspaper of Leaguetown High School. From the given information, write a **news story** as you would for the high school newspaper. You may use statements attributed to individuals as **direct or indirect quotes**. You may not change the meaning of a statement. You have **45 minutes**. Do not write your name or the name of your school on this sheet or your entry. **Put your number on your paper.**

Leaguetown High School has 700 students enrolled in grades 9-12. In April, two sophomores, Cindi Barry and Sasha Cantor, started a petition requesting that the school add student pronouns to class rosters and student ID cards. The petition states, “When someone is referred to with the wrong pronoun, it can make them feel disrespected, invalidated, dismissed, alienated or dysphoric (or, often, all of the above). We respectfully request that the school ask students their pronouns and put them on class rosters and ID cards for the 2022-23 school year.”

More than 500 students have signed the petition, and several teachers have expressed support for the change on rosters and ID cards. Librarian Suzanne Gregg makes the school ID cards. She said a pronoun line could be added to the card without any additional cost.

The sophomores will present the petition to the school board at its meeting next Thursday, May 19, because Principal Nia Bernal said the change would need board approval.

This Wednesday, Bernal will host a parent meeting to discuss the petition. In her email to parents, she said she wanted to “gauge parent feelings” about possible changes to rosters and ID cards.

You are writing for the issue of the Press to be distributed Monday, May 9.

■ CINDI BARRY, sophomore

“Sasha and I want the change to support transgender students. We have a friend who goes to another school, and she is transgender. Her teachers and other students often use the pronoun ‘he’ or ‘him’ when they talk about her. She said it makes her feel as though someone is saying, ‘You’re not really a female’ and she has to defend her existence. And this happens every day, she said. Sasha and I don’t know any transgender students here at the school, but that doesn’t mean there aren’t any. We just want to help the school create an environment where everyone feels safe, respected and valued. The change will cost the school nothing, and it could help students and teachers connect better.”

■ SASHA CANTOR, sophomore

“Not a single student has given us any pushback on the petition. In fact, everyone we have asked has signed the petition. Teachers have told us it is a good idea.

“I am confused as to why Ms. Bernal called a parent meeting if this decision isn’t hers to make. When I asked Ms. Bernal about it, she said she wants to make sure parents agree because she’s not sure the change is necessary. Again, that doesn’t make sense to me. It’s frustrating that Ms.

■ SASHA CANTOR, cont.

Bernal called this parent meeting and didn't invite Cindi or me. We plan to attend to answer parent questions and defend our petition. This change wouldn't affect any student negatively, nor is it costly or time-consuming. I was born female and identify female. I would put 'she' on rosters and my ID card. It feels like Ms. Bernal called the meeting to give the parents time to rally opposition to the petition. She said that is not her intent, but I am not convinced."

■ NIA BERNAL, principal

"Leaguetown is a small town and a tight-knit community. Our parents are well-informed about what happens in our school, and I want to keep it that way. I called the meeting to share information and gauge parent opinions. The school board will want to know how parents feel about this. Personally, I am confused about the petition. If we had transgender students asking for this change, then it would make more sense. These two students are female and identify as female. If the decision were up to me, I would leave things the way they are. I don't want Leaguetown to end up on the evening news or in the crosshairs of Texas politicians."

■ LEESA ROSKINS, English teacher

"The girls' petition is mature and thoughtful, and it could help some students. Unfortunately, I don't think all of our students would take it seriously. I overheard two freshman boys talking about the petition, and they said they wanted to put 'she/her' on their IDs and class rosters to 'mess with the teachers.' Not all of our students are mature enough to take on this change."

■ VERA PARTER, social studies teacher

"Cindi and Sasha's petition makes sense and is needed. Right now, I don't believe we have any transgender students, but that hasn't always been the case. Two years ago, I had a transgender male student. He often brought his lunch to my room because he said he felt isolated and alienated. Asking students to identify their pronouns on their IDs and class rosters sends a message that we respect everyone. Every student matters here. It's a powerful message I hope our school board adopts."

■ BOB THORNE, junior

"I signed the petition. This issue doesn't affect me, but it might help other students. That's what Cindi and Sasha are trying to do — help other people. I don't see how that causes harm to anyone."

■ ZOE ROMERO, parent

"I appreciate Ms. Bernal calling a parent meeting to keep us informed. I don't feel like she has an ulterior motive. We live in a complicated world, and she is trying to navigate it with transparency and information. My daughter told me about the petition and said she signed it. I am proud of her. I believe most parents will support what the petition wants."

■ ADDITIONAL INFORMATION

In September at Southside High School, which is 20 miles from Leaguetown, more than 90% of the students signed a petition requesting a gender-neutral bathroom at the school. When the principal and school board denied the request, the national media showed up. Several Texas politicians also got involved. The school still has no gender-neutral bathroom.

DO NOT DISTRIBUTE TO STUDENTS BEFORE OR DURING THE CONTEST!

STATE • 2022

NEWS WRITING CONTEST TIPS AND SAMPLE STORY

Contest Director: Give one copy to each judge to use during critique/judging. Also, staple one copy of the contest and one copy of the contest tips to each student's returned entry. The purpose of the tips is to provide immediate feedback to students. However, it is not meant to replace written comments from the judge.

1. As a general rule, open with a future lead. Here, the story comes out before the parent meeting and before the students present the petition to the school board.

Before two students present a petition to the school board requesting pronouns on class rosters and school IDs, Principal Nia Bernal said she will host a parent meeting Wednesday about the request to “gauge parent opinions.”

Sophomores Cindi Barry and Sasha Cantor organized the petition and will present it to the board on May 19.

2. Use direct quotes early in the story. After you introduce quotes, use the transition/quote formula. Be sure you attribute after the quote. An attribution should be: subject of attribution followed by the verb of attribution (“Bernal said,” not “said Bernal.”) Avoid stacking quotes. Avoid putting two or more quotes from different people together without placing a transition between them. Also, make sure transitions provide information and the quote does not repeat information revealed in the transition.

transition

Cantor said she's confused as to why Bernal called the meeting.

direct quote

“When I asked Ms. Bernal about it, she said she wants to make sure the parents agree because she's not sure the change is needed,” Cantor said. “That doesn't make sense to me. It feels like Ms. Bernal called the meeting to give the parents time to rally opposition to the petition. She said that's not her intent, but I am not convinced.”

transition

Cantor said she's frustrated that they were not invited to speak at the meeting.

direct quote

“We plan to attend to answer parent questions and defend our petition,” Cantor said. “This change wouldn't affect any student negatively, nor is it costly or time-consuming.”

3. Use third person. Don't say “our students” or “our sophomore Cindi Barry” or “Some of our students ...” Also, do not editorialize. For instance, you should not say “the proposal is smart...” without attributing that quote to someone.

4. Note how in the earlier example of transition/quote, each quote is its own paragraph. Don't be afraid to use one or two-sentence paragraphs.

5. Make sure both sides are represented in your story. Try to be as objective as possible.

SAMPLE STORY

Before two students present a petition to the school board requesting pronouns on class rosters and school IDs, Principal Nia Bernal said she will host a parent meeting Wednesday about the request to “gauge parent opinions.”

Sophomores Cindi Barry and Sasha Cantor organized the petition and will present it to the board on May 19.

The petition states, “When someone is referred to with the wrong pronoun, it can make them feel disrespected, invalidated, dismissed, alienated or dysphoric (or, often, all of the above.) We respectfully request that the school ask students their pronouns and put them on all class rosters and ID cards for the 2022-23 school year.”

Cantor said she’s confused as to why Bernal called the meeting.

“When I asked Ms. Bernal about it, she said she wants to make sure the parents agree because she’s not sure the change is needed,” Cantor said. “That doesn’t make sense to me. It feels like Ms. Bernal called the meeting to give the parents time to rally opposition to the petition. She said that’s not her intent, but I am not convinced.”

Cantor said she’s frustrated that they were not invited to speak at the meeting.

“We plan to attend to answer parent questions and defend our petition,” Cantor said. “This change wouldn’t affect any student negatively, nor is it costly or time-consuming.”

Bernal said her goal for the meeting is to keep parents informed.

“The school board will want to know how our parents feel about this,” she said.

More than 500 students have signed the petition so far.

“Not a single student has given us any pushback on the petition,” Cantor said. “In fact, everyone we have asked has signed the petition.”

Barry said they started the petition to support transgender students.

“We have a friend who goes to another school, and she is transgender,” she said. “Her teachers and other students often use the pronouns he or him when they talk about her. She said it makes her feel as though someone is saying ‘You’re not really a woman,’ and she has to defend her existence. We want to help the school create an environment where everyone feels safe, respected and valued.”

Social studies teacher Vera Parter agreed the change is needed.

“Right now, I don’t believe we have any transgender students, but that hasn’t always been the case,” she said. “Two years ago, I had a transgender male student. He often brought his lunch in my room because he said he felt isolated and alienated.”

English teacher Leesa Roskins said she worries that some students wouldn’t take it seriously.

“I overheard two freshman boys talking about the petition, and they said they wanted to put ‘she/her’ on their IDs and class rosters to ‘mess with the teachers,’” Roskins said. “Not all of our students are mature enough to take on this change.”

But Parter said asking students to identify their pronouns on their IDs and class rosters sends a message that the school respects all students.

“Every student matters here,” she said. “It’s a powerful message that I hope our school board adopts.”

2022 NEWS WRITING STATE CHAMPIONS

1A

Alaina Goodwin - Chireno HS

In an attempt to give all students a welcoming environment, sophomores Cindi Barry and Sasha Cantor began a petition requesting that the district adds student pronouns to their school ID cards. Principal Nia Bernal will host a parent meeting on Wednesday to discuss the matter, while Barry and Cantor will present the petition at the school board meeting Thursday, May 19.

"Sasha and I don't know any transgender students here at the school, but that doesn't mean there aren't any," Barry said. "We just want to help the school create an environment where everyone feels safe, respected and valued."

As well as having support from teachers, more than 500 students have signed the petition to change the ID cards for the 2022-2023 school year.

"Not a single student has given us any pushback on the petition," Cantor said. "In fact, everyone we have asked has signed the petition. Teachers have told us it is a good idea."

According to the librarian who makes the school ID cards, Suzanne Greg, a pronoun line on the cards could be added without any additional cost.

"The change will cost the school nothing, and it could help students and teachers connect better," Barry said.

However, Bernal has opposing opinions about Barry and Cantor's petition since there are no transgender students in the school.

"Personally, I am confused about the petition. If we had transgender students asking for this change, then it would make more sense. These two students are female and identify as female," Bernal said. "If the decision were up to me, I would leave things the way they are."

Despite what some think about the parent meeting, Bernal states that the purpose is solely to "gauge parent feelings" and inform them about the possible change.

"Leaguetown is a small town and a tight-knit community," Bernal said. "Our parents are well-informed about what happens in our school, and I want to keep it that way."

Without an invitation, Barry and Cantor plan to attend the meeting in order to answer questions that parents may have, as well as encourage them to support their petition.

"Bernal called this parent meeting and didn't invite Cindi or me," Cantor said. "We plan to attend to answer parent questions and defend our petition. This change wouldn't affect any student negatively, nor is it costly or time-consuming."

Having a transgender friend attending another school, Barry and Cantor have heard of the mistreatment that she receives. They hope that pronouns will be added to student ID cards in order to prevent accidental disrespect.

"Her teachers and other students around her often use the pronoun 'he' or 'him' when they talk about her," Barry said. "She said it feels as though someone is saying, 'You're not really a female' and she has to defend her existence."

Following a petition circulated by sophomores Cindi Barry and Sasha Cantor requesting that the school add student pronouns to ID cards and class rosters, Principal Nia Bernal said the change would require board approval. Barry and Cantor will present the petition to the school board at its meeting on Thursday, May 19. Bernal will host a parent meeting to discuss the petition on Wednesday.

The petition was created in April in response to the experiences of Barry and Cantor's transgender friend, who attends another school.

"Her teachers and other students often use the pronoun 'he' or 'him' when they talk about her. It makes her feel as though she has to defend her existence," Barry said. "We just want to help the school create an environment where everyone feels safe, respected and valued."

Since its creation, the petition has garnered over 500 student signatures and the support of several teachers.

"Not a single student has given us any pushback on the petition," Cantor said. "In fact, everyone we have asked has signed the petition. Teachers has told us it is a good idea."

In an email to parents, Bernal said she is hosting the meeting to "gauge parent feelings." Barry and Cantor were not invited.

"I am confused as to why Ms. Bernal called a parent meeting if this decision isn't hers to make," Cantor said. "We plan to attend to answer parent questions and defend our petition."

In September, a petition signed by over 90% of nearby Southside High School's student body to implement a gender-neutral bathroom was denied by the principal and school board, gaining media attention. Bernal said she hopes to avoid a similar situation.

"Our parents are well-informed about what happens in our school, and I want to keep it that way. If the decision were up to me, I would leave things the way they are," she said. "I don't want to end up on the evening news or in the crosshairs of Texas politicians."

Parent Zoe Romero said she is appreciative of Bernal's call for a parent meeting.

"We live in a complicated world, and she is trying to navigate it with transparency and information," Romero said. "My daughter told me about the petition and said she signed it. I believe parents will support what the petition wants."

English teacher Leesa Roskins said the petition is well-intended, but some students will be incapable of taking it seriously.

"I overheard two freshman boys talking about the petition and said they wanted to put 'she/her' on their IDs and class rosters to 'mess with the teachers,'" Roskins said. "Not all of our students are mature enough to make this change."

Adding a pronoun line to school ID cards would come at no additional cost. Junior Bob Thorne said he signed the petition and believes the request is harmless.

"This issue doesn't affect me, but it might help other students. That's what Cindi and Sasha are trying to do- help other people," he said.

Social studies teacher Vera Parter said the change is needed after teaching a transgender male student two years ago.

“Asking students to identify their pronouns on their IDs and class rosters sends a message that we respect everyone,” Parter said. “Every student matters here. It’s a powerful message I hope our school board adopts.

In response to a petition proposed by two sophomores, Cindi Barry and Sasha Cantor, requesting that the school ask students about their pronouns and put them on their class roster and ID cards, Principal Nia Bernal is hosting a parent meeting this Wednesday. The meeting is intended to gauge parent feelings about the potential changes if the petition is approved by the school board next Thursday, May 19.

The petition has been signed by over 500 students and has received support from other faculty members. Librarian Suzanne Gregg is in charge of making the school ID cards and says the pronoun line could be added without any additional cost.

"Not a single student has given us any pushback on the petition," Cantor said. "In fact, everyone we have asked has signed the petition. Teachers have told us it is a good idea."

Barry and Cantor want the change to support transgender students. Barry's friend who attends another school is transgender, and often their pronouns are misused.

"She said it makes her feel as though someone is saying, 'You're not really a female' and she has to defend her existence," Barry said. "And this happens every day, she said"

Two years ago, social studies teacher Vera Parter recalls a situation with a transgender student where inclusive pronoun ID cards may have helped his negative situation.

"He often brought his lunch to my room because he said he felt isolated and alienated," Parter said. "Asking students to identify their pronouns on their ID's and class rosters sends a message that we respect everyone. Every student matters here."

The positive feedback from teachers and students has left Cantor confused on why Bernal is calling a parent meeting.

"When I asked Bernal about it, she said she wants to make sure parents agree because she's not sure the change is necessary," Cantor said. "Bernal called this parent meeting and didn't invite Cindi or me. We plan to attend to answer parent questions and defend our petition."

Bernal wants to keep parents well informed about what goes on in the school because of the tight-knit community.

"The school board will want to know how parents feel about this," Bernal said. "Personally, I am confused about the petition. If we had transgender students asking for this change, then it would make more sense. These two students are female and identify as female."

Students that do not identify as transgender like junior Bob Thorne signed the petition support others.

"This issue doesn't affect me, but it might help other students," Thorne said. "That's what Cindi and Sasha are trying to do- help other people. I don't see how that causes harm to anyone."

Parent Zoe Romero believes that Bernal's intention with the meeting are good and that there is no ulterior motive to influence parents.

"We live in a complicated world, and she is trying to navigate it with transparency and information," Romero said. "My daughter told me about this petition and she signed it. I am proud of her. I believe most parents will support what the petition wants."

Barry believes that the petition is to solve a simple issue that can have a great impact on students. "We just wanted to help the school create an environment where everyone feels safe, respected and valued," Barry said. "The change will cost the school nothing and it could help students and teachers connect better."

After two sophomores, Cindi Barry and Sasha Cantor, started a petition requesting that the school add student pronouns to class rosters and student ID cards, Principal Nia Bernal will host a parent meeting Wednesday to discuss the possible changes. The sophomores will present the petition to the school board at its next meeting, Thursday May 19.

"Leaguetown is a small town and a tight-knit community," Bernal said. "Our parents are well-informed about what happens in our school, and I want to keep it that way."

The petition starts, "When someone is referred to with the wrong pronoun, it can make them feel disrespected, invalidated, dismissed, alienated or dysphoric (or often, all of the above)." Barry said she and Sasha want the change to support transgender students.

"We want to help the school create an environment where everyone feels safe, respected and valued," Barry said. "The change will cost the school nothing, and it could help students and teachers connect better."

More than 500 students have signed the petition, and several teachers have expressed support for the change on rosters and ID cards.

"Asking students to identify their pronouns on their IDs and class rosters sends a message that we respect everyone," social studies teacher Vera Parter said. "Every student matters here. It's a powerful message I hope our school board adopts."

Although not invited, Cantor said she plans on attending the parent meeting with Barry to answer any parent questions and defend the petition.

"This change wouldn't affect any student negatively, nor is it costly or time-consuming," Cantor said. "It feels like Ms. Bernal called the meeting to give the parents time to rally opposition to the petition."

In September at Southside High School, more than 90% of the students signed a petition requesting a gender-neutral bathroom at the school. When the principal and school board denied the request, the national media showed up.

"If the decision were up to me, I would leave things the way they are," Bernal said. "I don't want Leaguetown to end up on the evening news or in the crosshairs of Texas politicians."

Parent Zoe Romero said she appreciated Ms. Bernal calling a parent meeting to keep everyone informed.

"We live in a complicated world, and she is trying to navigate it with transparency and information," Romero said. "My daughter told me about the petition and said she signed it. I am proud of her. I believe more parents will support what the petition wants."

Principal Nia Bernal will host a parent meeting this Wednesday to discuss a petition two sophomores started before the students present it to the school board at its next meeting Thursday, May 19. The petition requests that the school add student pronouns to class rosters and student ID cards. The pronoun line could be added to the student ID cards without any additional cost.

Bernal said she called the meeting to share information and gather parent opinions because the school board will want to know how parents feel about it.

"Personally, I am confused about the petition," Bernal said. "If we had transgender students asking for this change, then it would make more sense."

Sasha Cantor, one of the sophomores who started the petition, said even though they are not invited to the parent meeting, they plan to attend to answer questions and defend the petition.

"This change wouldn't affect any student negatively, nor is it costly or time-consuming," Sasha said. "It feels like Ms. Bernal called the meeting to give the parents time to rally opposition to the petition. She said that is not her intent, but I am not convinced."

Cindi Barry, the other sophomore who started the petition, said she has a friend from another school who is transgender and people often use the wrong pronoun when they talk about her. Cindi said even though she doesn't know any transgender students here at school, that doesn't mean there aren't any.

"We just want to help the school create an environment where everyone feels safe, respected, and valued," Cindi said. "The change will cost the school nothing, and it could help students and teachers connect better."

So far, more than 500 students have signed the petition, and several teachers have expressed support for the change. Bob Thorne, a junior who signed the petition said the issue doesn't affect him, but it might help other students.

"That's what Cyndi and Sasha are trying to do—help other people," Thorne said. "I don't see how that causes harm to anyone."

Social studies teacher Vera Parker said the petition makes sense and is needed. Parker also said she doesn't believe the school has any transgender students right now, but they have had some in the past.

"Asking students to identify their pronouns on their IDs and class rosters sends a message that we respect everyone," Parker said. "Every student matters here. It's a powerful message I hope our school board adopts."

English teacher Leesa Roskins agrees that petition could help some students, but doesn't think students will take it seriously.

"I overheard two freshman boys talking about the petition, and they said they wanted to put 'she/her' on their IDs and class rosters to 'mess with the teachers,'" Roskins said. "Not all our students are mature enough to take on this change."

Parent Zoe Romero said she appreciates Ms. Bernal calling a parent meeting to keep them informed.

“I don’t feel like she has an ulterior motive,” Romero said. “We live in a complicated world, and she is trying to navigate it with transparency and information. My daughter told me about the petition and said she signed it. I am proud of her. I believe most parents will support what the petition wants.”

In September at Southside High School, more than 90% of students signed a petition that requested a gender-neutral bathroom at the school. When the principal and school board denied the request, the national media showed up and Texas politicians got involved.

“If the decision were up to me, I would leave things the way they are,” Bernal said. “I don’t want Leaguetown to end up on the evening news or in the crosshairs of Texas politicians.”

Following a petition by two sophomores regarding the addition of student pronouns to class rosters and ID cards, Principal Nia Bernal will host a parent meeting to discuss the matter this Wednesday before the students present their petition to the school board May 19.

In April, sophomores Cindi Barry and Sasha Cantor started a petition requesting that pronouns be added to class rosters and student ID cards for the 2022-2023 school year to help all students feel respected and welcome at school regardless of their gender identity.

"Sasha and I want the change to support transgender students," Barry said. "We just want to help the school create an environment where everyone feels safe, respected and valued."

The petition was inspired by a transgender friend of the students' who goes to another school and has faced many challenges, leading her to feel alienated.

"Her teachers and other students often use the pronoun 'he' or 'him' when they talk about her," Barry said. "She said it makes her feel as though someone is saying 'You're not really a female' and she had to defend her existence. And this happens every day."

The number of transgender students is unknown but that does not mean there are no students that need this change. Additionally, more than 500 students have signed the petition.

"Not a single student has given us any pushback on the petition," Cantor said. "In fact, everyone we have asked has signed the petition."

Although being misgendered may not affect many students, the other students are aware of how much it could help others.

"I signed the petition," junior Bob Thorne said. "This issue doesn't affect me but it might help other students. That's what Cindi and Sasha are trying to do—help other people."

Many teachers are in support of adding pronouns to IDs and rosters as they think it is a good idea.

"Cindi and Sasha's petition makes sense and is needed," social studies teacher Vera Parter said. "Asking students to identify their pronouns on their IDs and class rosters sends a message that we respect everyone."

However some teachers fear that many of the students lack the maturity to respond correctly to the change.

"I don't think all of our students would take it seriously," English teacher Leesa Roskins said. "I overheard two freshman boys talking about the petition and they said they wanted to put 'she/her' on their IDs and class rosters to 'mess with the teachers'."

Maturity is not the only obstacle that faces this petition as Bernal is insistent on hosting a parent meeting to "gauge parent feelings" on the matter.

"Our parents are well-informed about what happens in our school and I want to keep it that way," Bernal said. "I called the meeting to share information. The school board will want to know how parents feel about this. Personally, I am confused about the petition."

The parent meeting is very frustrating to Cantor as the decision is not up to Bernal and would not affect any student negatively nor would it cost the school any additional fees as librarian Suzanne Gregg who makes the ID cards can add pronouns free of cost but parents do appreciated the meeting.

"I appreciate Ms. Bernal calling a parent meeting to keep us informed," parent Zoe Romero said. I don't feel like she has an ulterior motive."

Cantor and Barry plan on to attend the parent meeting to answer questions and defend the petition and then go on to present their case to the school board in their attempt to help all students feel respected and validated.

"Everyone matters her. It's a powerful message I hope our school board adopts," Parter said.